

OP11 Project Ownership and Accountability

Absorbs relevant elements from E11 (Fostering Project Ownership, Enablement pillar).

Pillar	Opportunity	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	40-50 minutes	Group Size	4-10
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Lack of encouragement for project ownership, limited ownership of high-impact projects, initiative and ownership signals low, micromanagement indicators

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Ownership activates the brain's intrinsic motivation circuitry. When a person feels genuine ownership over a project (not just responsibility for tasks within it), the brain treats outcomes as personally meaningful. Dopamine flows from progress, serotonin from the sense of contribution, and the prefrontal cortex engages fully in planning and problem-solving because the stakes feel real.

The opposite of ownership is compliance: doing what you're told without personal investment. Compliance uses minimal cognitive resources, produces minimal dopamine, and generates no serotonin. The person completes the work but gains nothing from it neurologically. Over time, compliance-mode work is indistinguishable from disengagement.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Ownership Diagnostic (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Think about the projects and tasks you're currently working on. For each one, ask yourself: do I own this, or am I just executing it? Ownership means you feel responsible for the outcome, you make decisions about how to get there, and you care whether it succeeds. Execution means someone told you what to do and you're doing it."

Each person maps their current work on a simple spectrum: Full Ownership / Shared Ownership / Executing / Unclear. The distribution reveals how much genuine ownership exists on the team.

Phase 2: Barriers to Ownership (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Where work sits in the 'executing' or 'unclear' categories, what's preventing ownership? Is it unclear authority? Lack of trust? Micromanagement? Not understanding the bigger picture? Or something else?"

Capture barriers. Common ones: manager reviews every decision, scope of authority is undefined, fear of being blamed if it goes wrong, not being included in the 'why' behind the project.

FACILITATION NOTE

If micromanagement surfaces as a barrier, the manager must hear this without defending. "I hear that. Some of what you're describing might be me. Tell me specifically where you feel you need more space, and I'll work on giving it to you." This is a V1-level vulnerability moment for the manager.

Phase 3: The Ownership Transfer (15 minutes)

For each team member, identify one piece of work where ownership can be expanded:

- What decision authority transfers to them? (be specific: "You decide the approach. I need to see the outcome.")
- What support do they need to own it successfully? (resources, information, access)
- What does success look like, and what happens if it doesn't work? (defining safe-to-fail boundaries, connecting to V7)

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm going to be specific about what I'm handing over and what I'm keeping. For [project/task], you now own [specific decisions]. I don't need to approve those. What I do need is [specific update cadence or milestone check]. If you hit a wall, come to me. Otherwise, it's yours."

Phase 4: Accountability Design (5 minutes)

Ownership without accountability is chaos. Each ownership transfer includes:

- Clear success criteria (what done looks like)
- Update cadence (how often the manager hears about progress, not how often they check)
- Escalation protocol (when the owner should involve the manager, and when they should solve it themselves)

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The manager struggles to	Start small: "You don't have to transfer ownership of the biggest project

let go of decision authority	on day one. Pick something where the risk is manageable and the learning is valuable. Build trust incrementally."
A team member doesn't want ownership (prefers being told what to do)	Explore why: "Is that because you genuinely prefer execution, or because you've learned that taking ownership here isn't safe?" If it's a safety issue, address that through V1/V7 first. If it's a genuine preference, respect it, but ensure they're still growing.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
E6: Decision-Making Autonomy	OP11 transfers ownership; E6 provides the decision-making framework to exercise it.	Complementary (run together)
V7: Reducing Fear of Failure	Ownership requires safe-to-fail boundaries. V7 provides the framework.	Run V7 before or alongside OP11
E3: Empowerment Through Delegation	E3 provides the delegation skill; OP11 provides the ownership transfer structure.	Complementary